some very exciting papers delving into exactly what that was going to be like. It was a heady time.

In the late 1990s, however, astronomers perfected a more precise method for measuring the expansion of the universe, involving stringing together several methods for measuring cosmic distance and applying them to extremely distant exploding stars. Finally, they could take the true measurement of the universe and determine, once and for all, its eventual fate. What they found shocked pretty much everyone, earned three of the team leads a Nobel Prize, and made a complete mess of our understanding of the fundamental workings of physics.

The fact that the discovery indicates that we are almost certainly safe from a fiery death in a Big Crunch has turned out to be cold comfort.[fn9] The alternative to recollapse is eternal expansion, which, like immortality, only sounds good until you really think about it. On the bright side, we're not doomed to perish in an apocalyptic cosmic inferno. On the, well, dark side, the most likely fate for our universe turns out to be, in its own way, much more upsetting.